

# Introduction to Machine Learning

## Lecture 10: Support Vector Machine

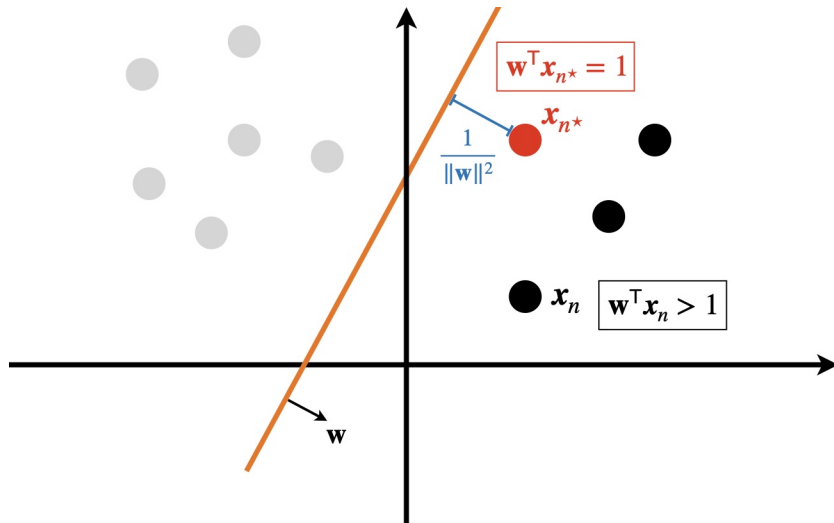
Ali Bereyhi

`ali.bereyhi@utoronto.ca`

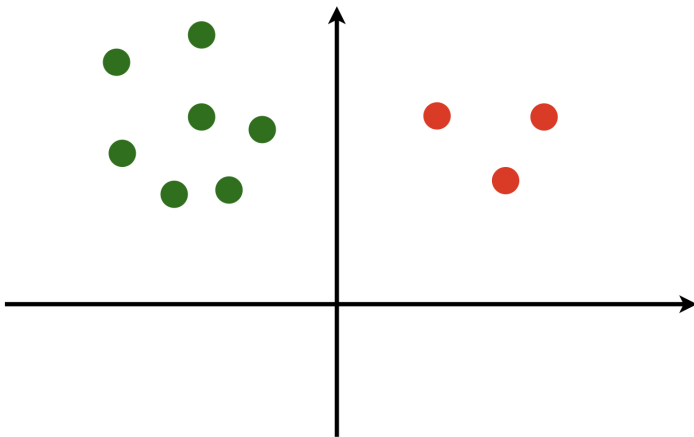
Department of Electrical and Computer Engineering  
University of Toronto

Winter 2026

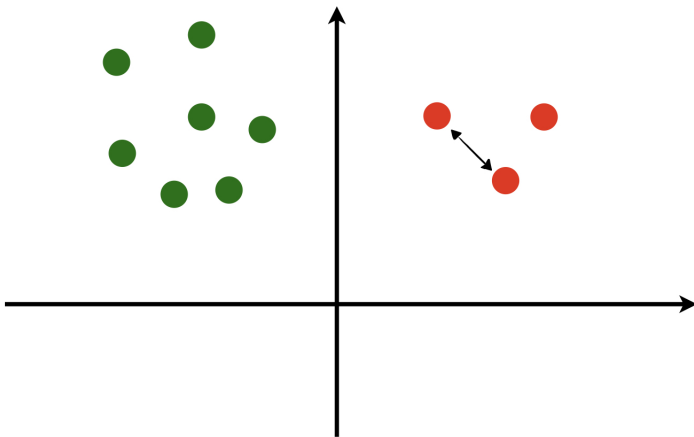
## Quick Recap: Support Vector Classifier



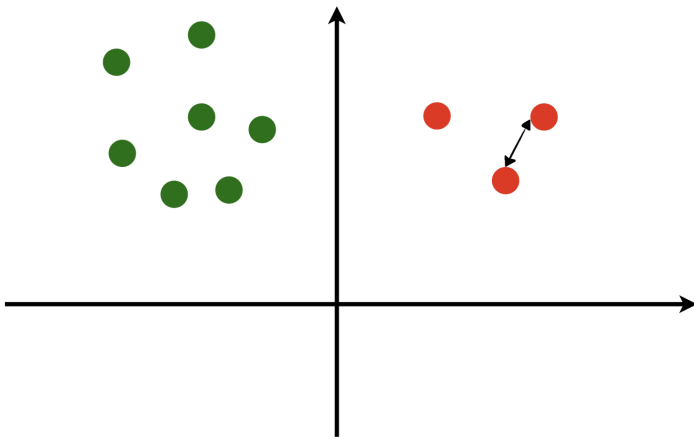
## Quick Recap: *SVC Training*



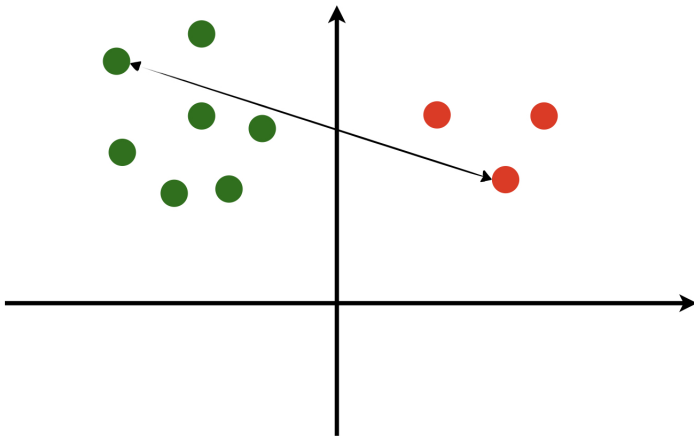
## Quick Recap: *SVC Training*



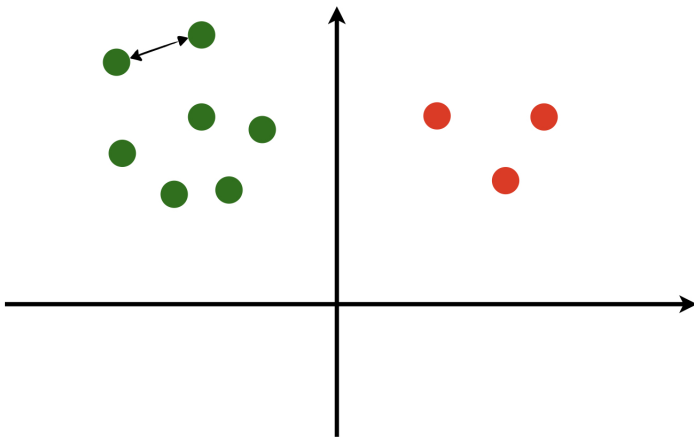
## Quick Recap: SVC Training



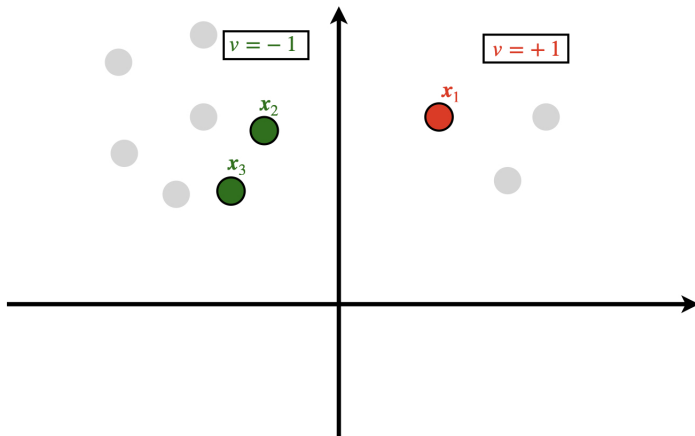
## Quick Recap: *SVC Training*



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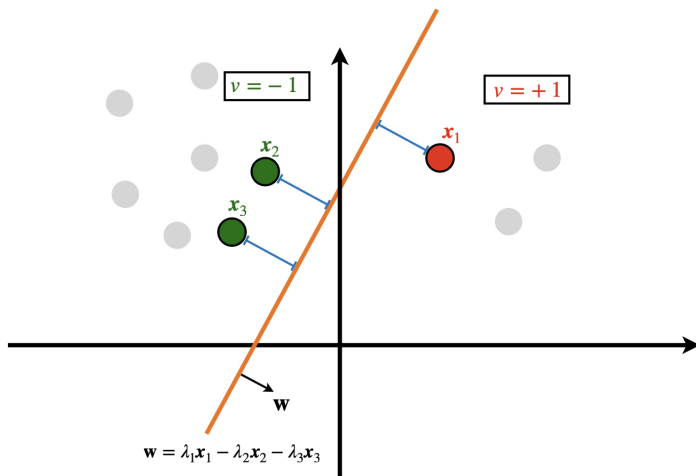


## Quick Recap: SVC Training

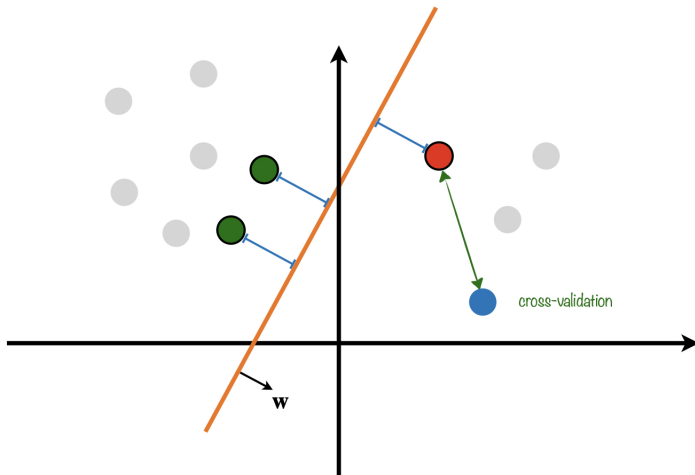




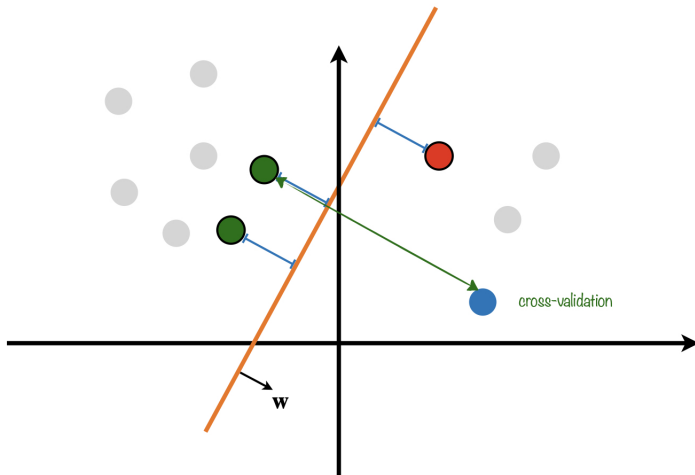
## Quick Recap: SVC Training



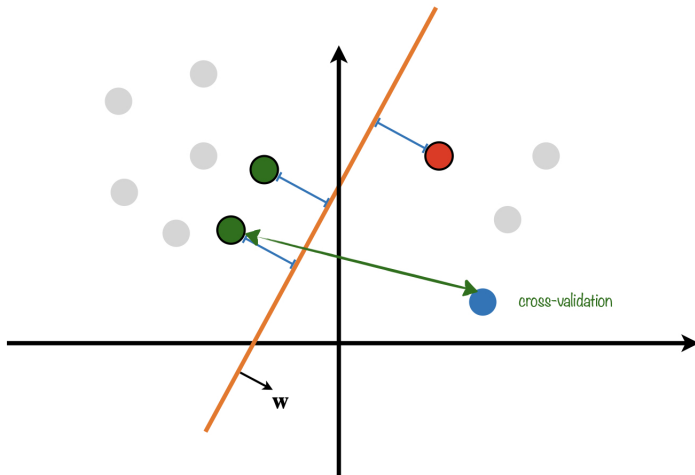
## Quick Recap: SVC Inference



## Quick Recap: *SVC Inference*



## Quick Recap: SVC Inference



# Today's Agenda: *Support Vector Machine*

*Today, we extend the idea of SVC to nonlinear settings through*

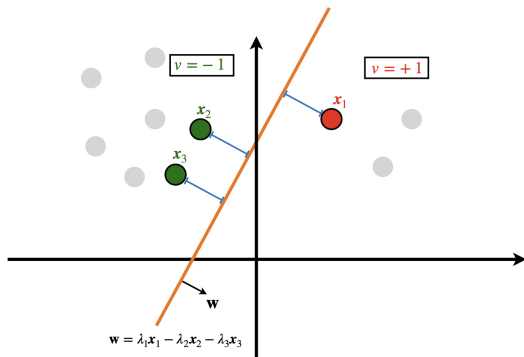
## *Support Vector Machine and Concept of Kernels*

*In this way, we discuss the following topics*

- *We extend the idea of SVC to nonlinear patterns via embedding*
- *We develop SVM via the kernel trick*
- *We get the notions of kernel and representation learning*

# SVC is Still Linear!

SVC can classify if it is *linearly separable*



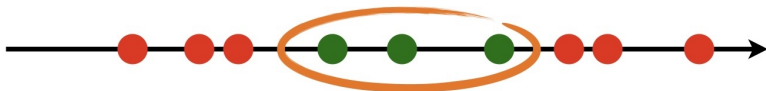
? What's going to happen if data is not so simply structures?

## Example I: Cat or Dog

? What if in our Cat or Dog example, the weights are sorted like this?



! Well, we need a *nonlinear* classifier then



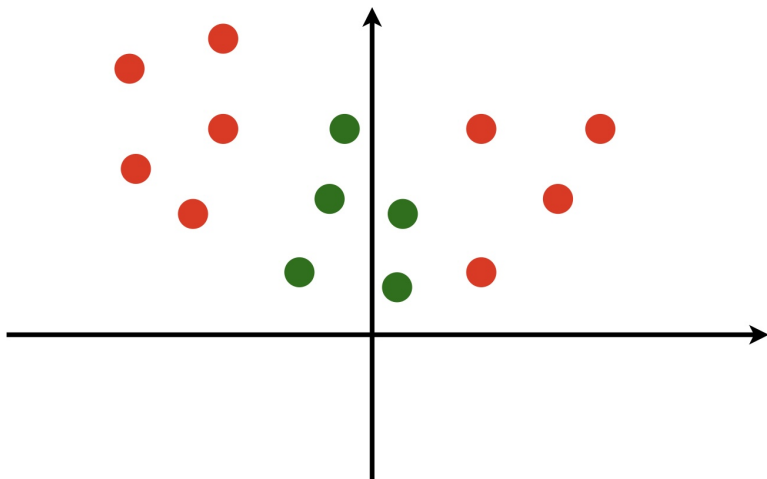
## Nonlinear Classifier

Classifier that infers class of samples from nonlinear computations, e.g.,

$$z_n = w_1 x_n + w_2 x_n^2 \rightsquigarrow y_n = \text{sign}(z_n)$$

## Example II: Curved Boundary

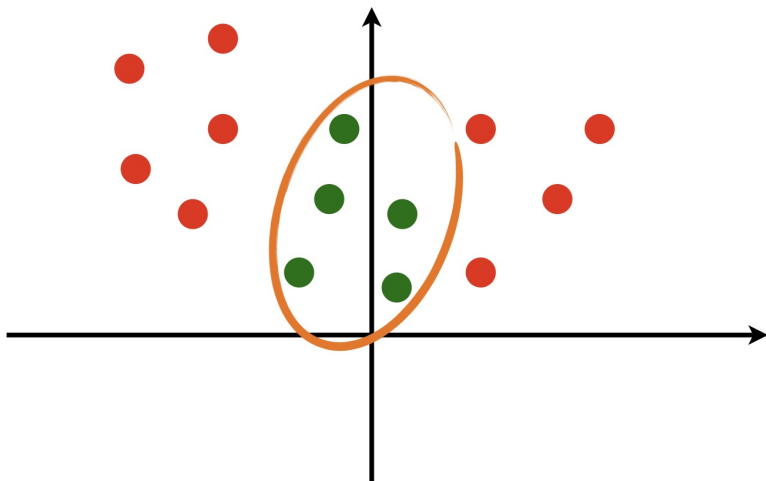
! *Such classifier should be needed in many problems*





## Example II: Curved Boundary

! *Such classifier should be needed in many problems*



## Example I: Cat or Dog

Let's get back to our Cat or Dog example: We have a dataset

$$\mathbb{D} = \{(x_n, v_n) : n = 1, \dots, N\}$$

But now we cannot simply divide the green points from red ones by thresholding



? How can we do it in a systematic way then?

## Example I: Cat or Dog

*Let's try a trick*



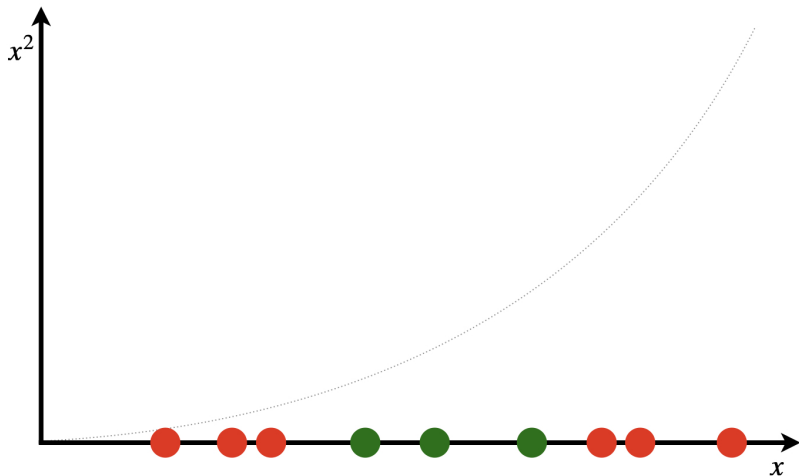
## Example I: Cat or Dog

*Let's try a trick: we add a second dimension to our data*



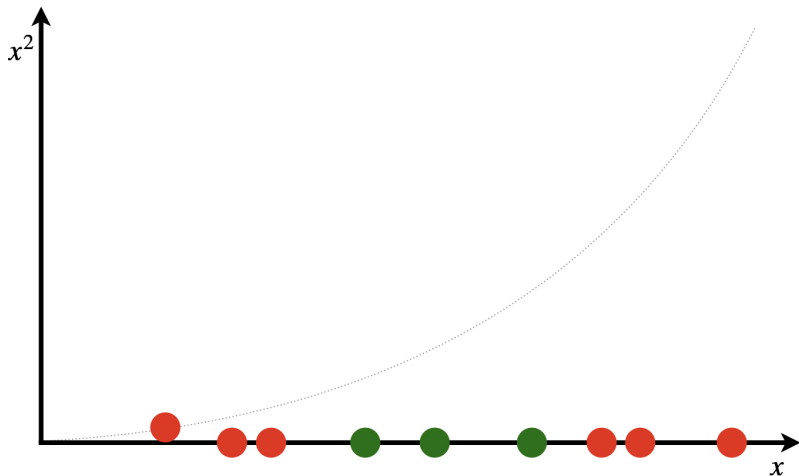
## Example I: Cat or Dog

*Let's try a trick: for this dimension we compute the square of samples*



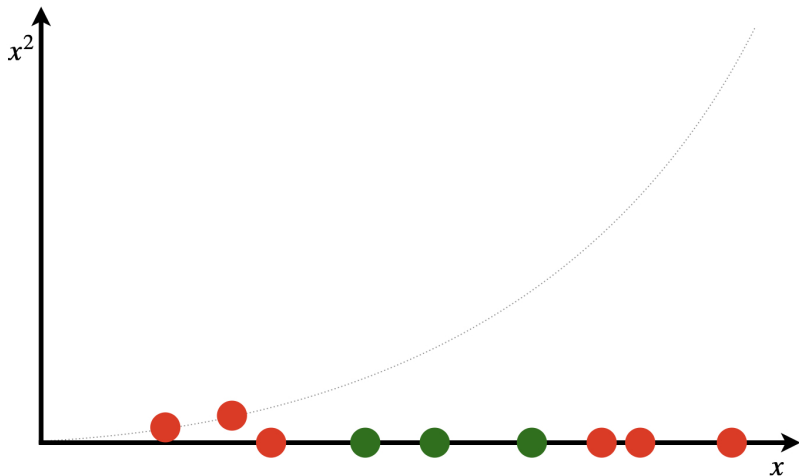
## Example I: Cat or Dog

Let's try a trick: now we represent each point with a new vector  $\tilde{x} = [x, x^2]$



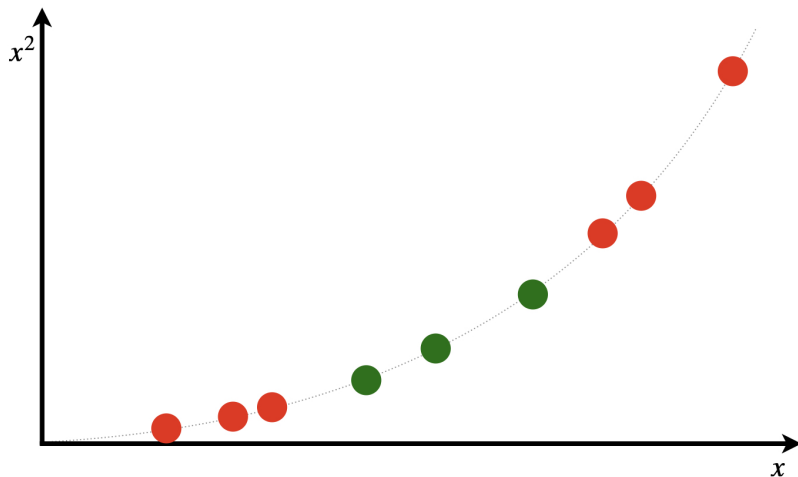
## Example I: Cat or Dog

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## Example I: Cat or Dog

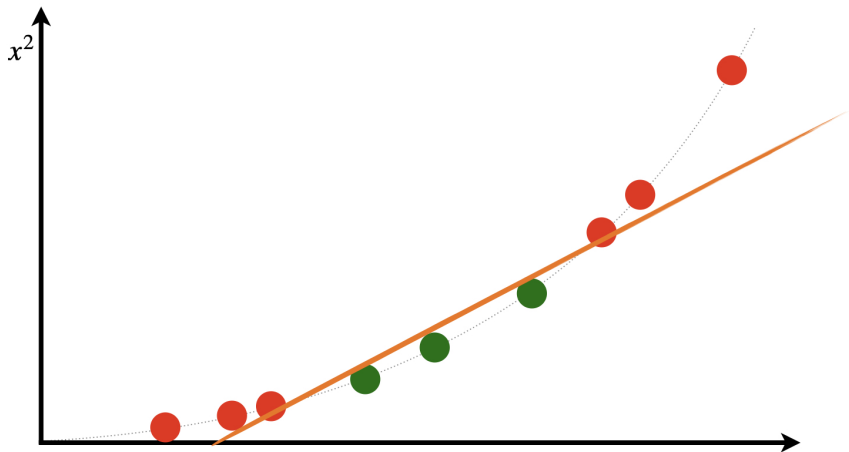
*Let's try a trick: we transform the whole dataset*





## Example I: Cat or Dog

*This transformed dataset can be linearly classified in 2D space!*



# Going Higher Dimensions

? *What is happening here?*

We see that the dataset **cannot** be classified perfectly by a linear model

*We extract high-dimensional features as*

$$x \mapsto \tilde{x} = \varphi(x) = \begin{bmatrix} x \\ x^2 \end{bmatrix}$$

*and see that*

$$\mathbb{D} = \{(\tilde{x}_n, v_n) : n = 1, \dots, N\}$$

*is classified by **linear model**!*

*We could make a **nonlinear** problem **linear in higher dimensions***

# Nonlinear Low-Dimension $\longleftrightarrow$ Linear High-Dimension

This suggests a generic recipe: *for a nonlinear problem with data*

$$\mathbb{D} = \{(\mathbf{x}_n, v_n) : n = 1, \dots, N\}$$

*first extract high-dimensional features*

## Feature Extraction: *Embedding*

*Use an embedding function  $\varphi$  to map samples to high-dimensional features*

$$\mathbf{x}_n \in \mathbb{R}^d \mapsto \varphi(\mathbf{x}_n) \in \mathbb{R}^D$$

*where  $D > d$*

# Nonlinear Low-Dimension $\longleftrightarrow$ Linear High-Dimension

This suggests a generic recipe: *for a nonlinear problem with data*

$$\mathbb{D} = \{(\mathbf{x}_n, v_n) : n = 1, \dots, N\}$$

*then find a linear classifier for high-dimensional features*

## Feature Classification

*Find a SVC with weight  $\mathbf{w} \in \mathbb{R}^D$  for  $\varphi(\mathbf{x}_n)$*

$$y_n = \text{sign} \left( \mathbf{w}^\top \varphi(\mathbf{x}_n) \right)$$

# Nonlinear Low-Dimension $\longleftrightarrow$ Linear High-Dimension

? *How to use the model for inferring class of a new data?*

*We infer based on the high-dimensional features*

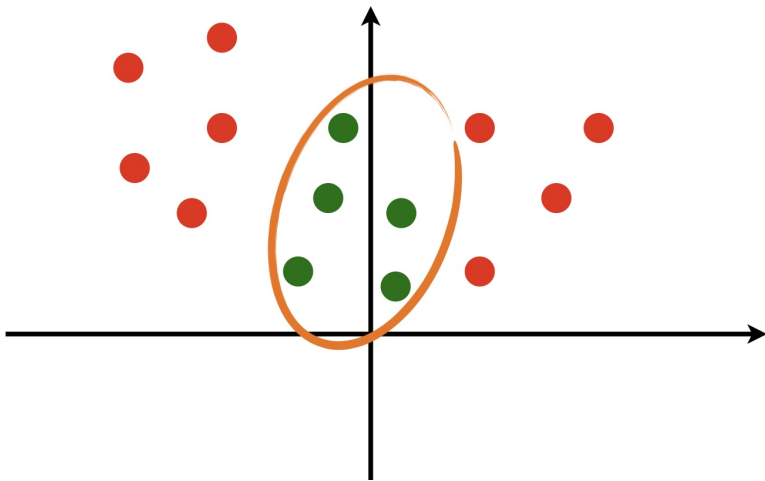
## Inference

*The label of the new sample  $\mathbf{x}$  is given as*

$$y = \text{sign} \left( \mathbf{w}^T \varphi(\mathbf{x}) \right)$$

## Example II: Curved Boundary

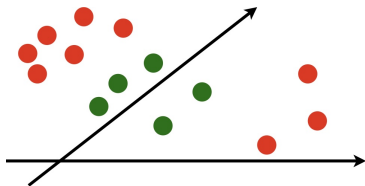
*Let's look at the round boundary visual example*



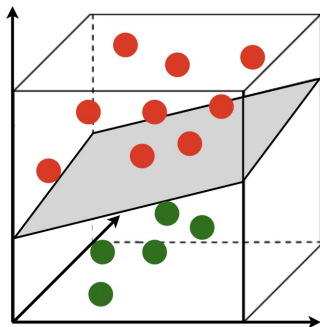
## Example II: Curved Boundary

*The points can be linearly separable in 3D*

*get the points  $x_n$  in 2D*



*maps them to 3D as  $\varphi(x_n)$*



# Support Vector Machine: *Nonlinear SVC*

## Support Vector Machine

Support vector machine (SVM) is an SVC that learns from high-dimensional features extract by an embedding function  $\varphi : \mathbb{R}^d \mapsto \mathbb{R}^D$

↳ It can learn nonlinear patterns

Though sounds promising, it seems a bit challenging

- ? What should be the embedding function?
- ? What if the model need super high-dimensional features?
  - ↳ This means that we should work in very high dimensions
  - ↳ We even don't know how large it should be!



## Recall: SVC Training and Inference

To train an SVC, we solve the dual problem

$$\max_{\lambda \geq 0} \sum_{n=1}^N \lambda_n - \frac{1}{2} \sum_{n=1}^N \sum_{m=1}^N \lambda_n \lambda_m v_n v_m \mathbf{x}_n^T \mathbf{x}_m$$

Once we found the dual values  $\lambda_n^*$ , we classify as

$$\mathbf{w}^* = \sum_{n=1}^N \lambda_n^* v_n \mathbf{x}_n \rightsquigarrow y = \text{sign} \left( \sum_{n=1}^N \lambda_n^* v_n \mathbf{x}_n^T \mathbf{x} \right)$$

## Recall: Only Cross-Validations

Recall that we only need the correlations  $\mathbf{x}_m^T \mathbf{x}_n$

## SVC with Embedded Features

For SVM, we would do the same: *we find the dual values through*

$$\max_{\lambda \geq 0} \sum_{n=1}^N \lambda_n - \frac{1}{2} \sum_{n=1}^N \sum_{m=1}^N \lambda_n \lambda_m v_n v_m \varphi(\mathbf{x}_n)^T \varphi(\mathbf{x}_m)$$

*We then infer the class of a new sample as*

$$\mathbf{w}^* = \sum_{n=1}^N \lambda_n^* v_n \varphi(\mathbf{x}_n) \rightsquigarrow y = \text{sign} \left( \sum_{n=1}^N \lambda_n^* v_n \varphi(\mathbf{x}_n)^T \varphi(\mathbf{x}) \right)$$

### Again: Only Cross-Validations

*Here again we only need the correlations  $\varphi(\mathbf{x}_m)^T \varphi(\mathbf{x}_n)$*

## Kernel Trick

We don't really need to work in high-dimensional space:

*It's enough to know how the embeddings are correlated!*

### Kernel

A function  $\mathcal{K} : \mathbb{R}^d \times \mathbb{R}^d \mapsto \mathbb{R}$  that computes the cross-correlation between high-dimensional features of two samples

$$\mathcal{K}(\mathbf{x}_m, \mathbf{x}_n) = \varphi(\mathbf{x}_n)^\top \varphi(\mathbf{x}_m)$$

We don't really need the embedding function  $\varphi$ :

we **only** need the **kernel**!

## Kernel Trick: *Extended Cross-Validation*

This is called the **kernel trick**: choose a kernel  $\mathcal{K}$  and solve

$$\max_{\lambda \geq 0} \sum_{n=1}^N \lambda_n - \frac{1}{2} \sum_{n=1}^N \sum_{m=1}^N \lambda_n \lambda_m v_n v_m \mathcal{K}(\mathbf{x}_m, \mathbf{x}_n)$$

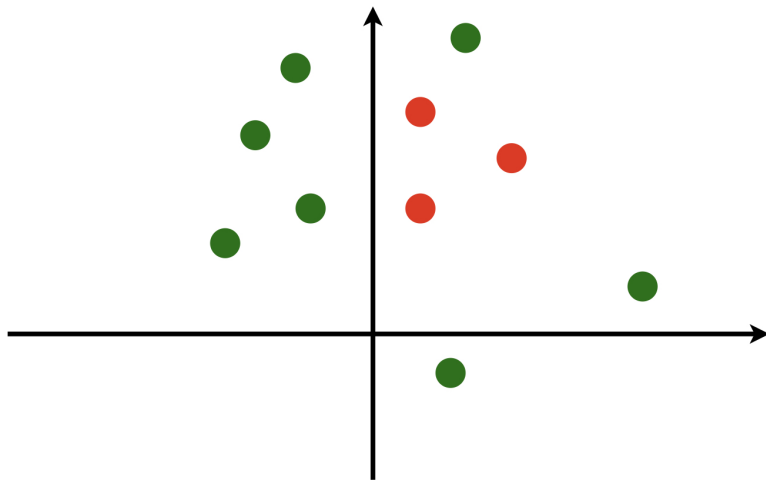
Once  $\lambda_n^*$  found classify by the same kernel  $\mathcal{K}$  as

$$\mathbf{w}^* = \sum_{n=1}^N \lambda_n^* v_n \varphi(\mathbf{x}_n) \rightsquigarrow y = \text{sign} \left( \sum_{n=1}^N \lambda_n^* v_n \mathcal{K}(\mathbf{x}_n, \mathbf{x}) \right)$$

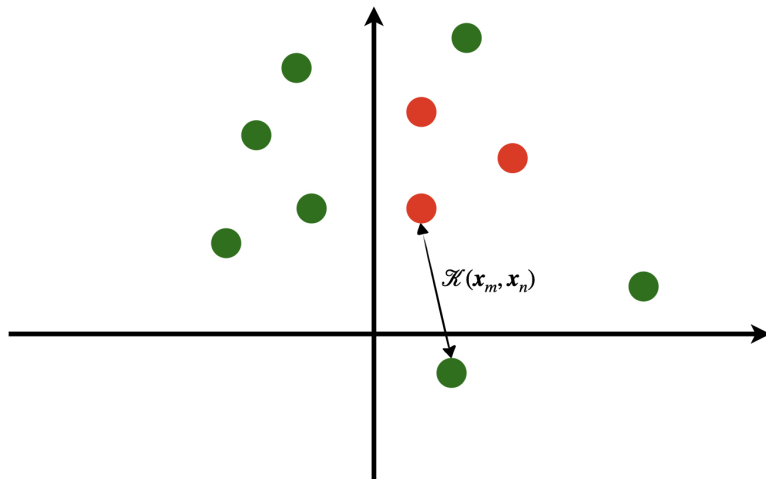
### Moral of Story

*SVM does what SVC do using a nonlinear (potentially very complicated) kernel*

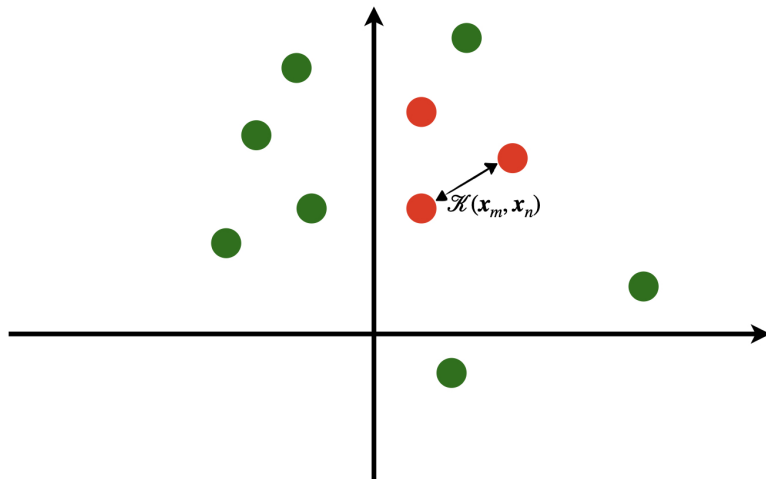
## Support Vector Machines: *Visualization*



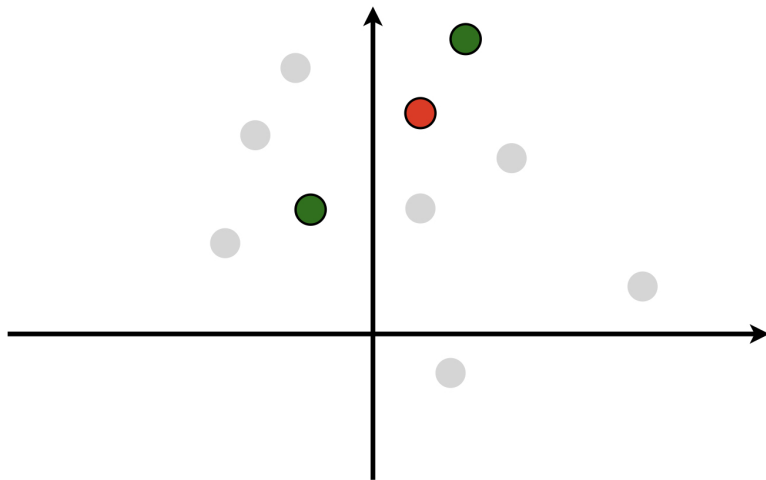
# Support Vector Machines: *Visualization*



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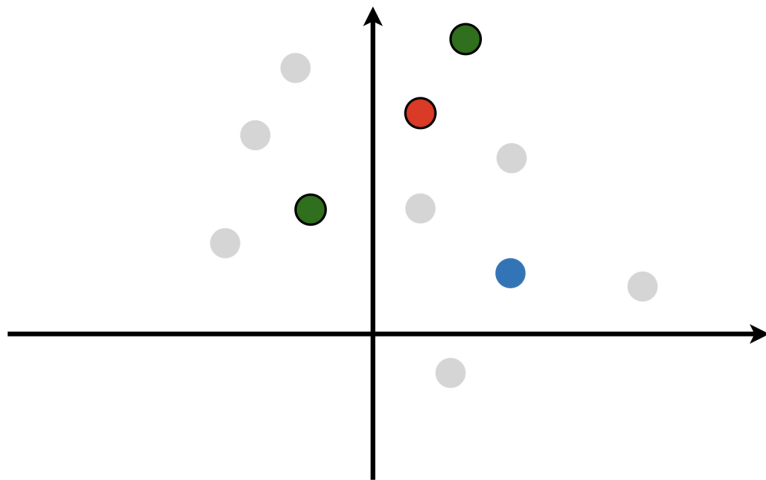


# Support Vector Machines: *Visualization*

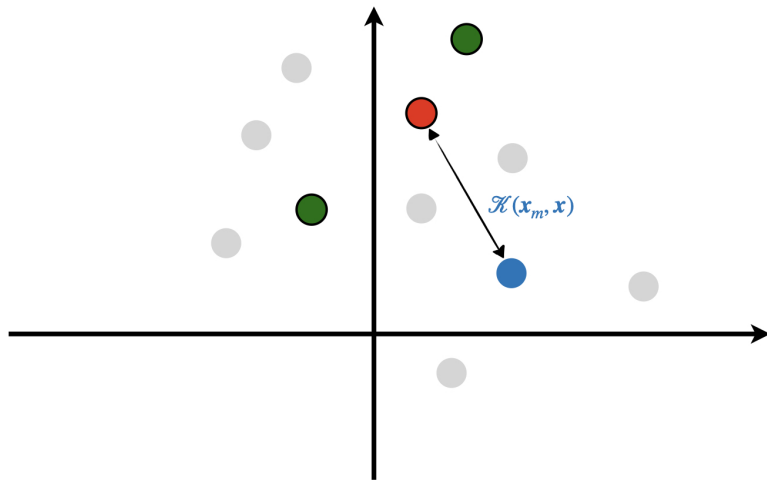




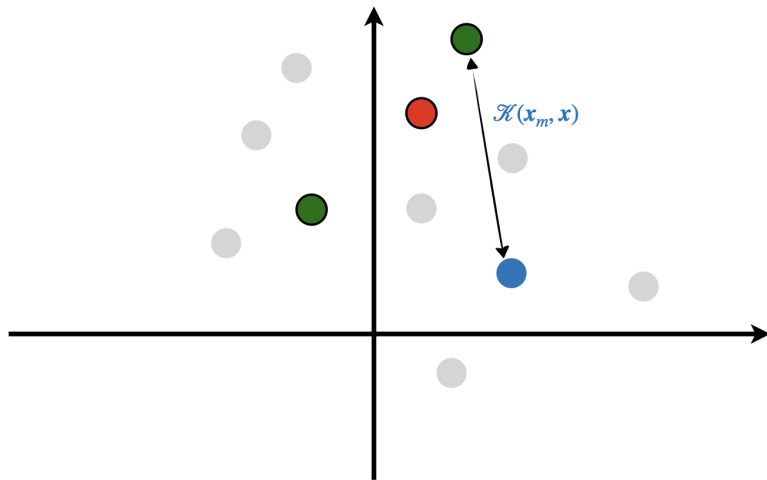
# Support Vector Machines: *Visualization*



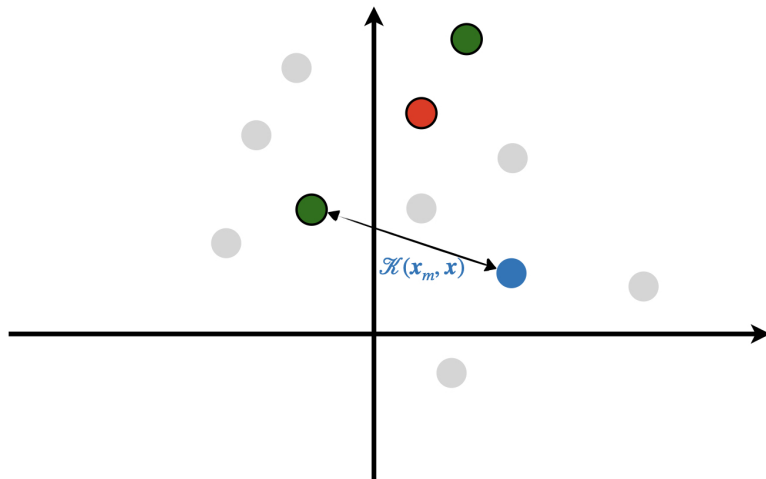
# Support Vector Machines: *Visualization*



# Support Vector Machines: *Visualization*



# Support Vector Machines: *Visualization*



## Famous Kernels: *Polynomial*

? *What should we choose as the kernel?*

! *There are some known choices*

### Polynomial Kernel

*The polynomial kernel of order  $p$  is defined as*

$$\mathcal{K}(\mathbf{x}_n, \mathbf{x}_m) = \left( \mathbf{x}_n^\top \mathbf{x}_m + c \right)^p$$

Corresponding embedding computes polynomial features

## Famous Kernels: *Polynomial* – *Example*

*Say order is 2, the samples are scalars and set  $c = 1$*

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{K}(x_n, x_m) &= (x_n x_m + 1)^2 \\ &= x_n^2 x_m^2 + 2x_n x_m + 1 \\ &= \begin{bmatrix} x_m^2 & \sqrt{2}x_m & 1 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} x_n^2 \\ \sqrt{2}x_n \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}\end{aligned}$$

*This is like our Cat or Dog example*

$$\varphi(x) = \begin{bmatrix} x^2 \\ \sqrt{2}x \\ 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

# Famous Kernels: *Gaussian Kernel*

## Gaussian (Radial) Kernel

The polynomial kernel of order  $p$  is defined as

$$\mathcal{K}(\mathbf{x}_n, \mathbf{x}_m) = \exp \left\{ -\frac{\|\mathbf{x}_n - \mathbf{x}_m\|^2}{\sigma} \right\}$$

The Gaussian kernel corresponds to

embedding in *infinite-dimensional* space!

Try to use Taylor series expansion of exponential function to see this

$$\exp \{x\} = 1 + x + \frac{x^2}{2!} + \cdots = \sum_{i=0}^{\infty} \frac{x^i}{i!}$$

# Preset Kernel $\equiv$ Feature Engineering

? *How do we know if we have chosen a good kernel?*

! *Nobody knows!*

## Feature Engineering

*By choosing a predefined kernel, we are implicitly setting the embedding functions. This is often called feature engineering, since we indirectly use a fixed rule for extracting features*

? *But is there any other way?*

! *Maybe, we can “let data speaks by itself”!*



## Representation Learning: *Learning Kernels*

We can instead set the kernel to be a parameterized function

$$\mathcal{K}_{\theta}(\mathbf{x}_m, \mathbf{x}_n)$$

If we use the SVM, our final loss depends on both  $\mathbf{w}$  and  $\theta$ : *we can train both*

$$\min_{\theta, \mathbf{w}} \hat{R}(\theta, \mathbf{w})$$

### Representation Learning

*We learn both the kernel and classifier together: this is like learning how to represent data first and then classify it*

**Example:** *We can leave  $\sigma$  in Gaussian kernel undecided and find it jointly with  $\mathbf{w}$*

# How to Find Excellent Representation

? *How can we find the right form for the kernel?*

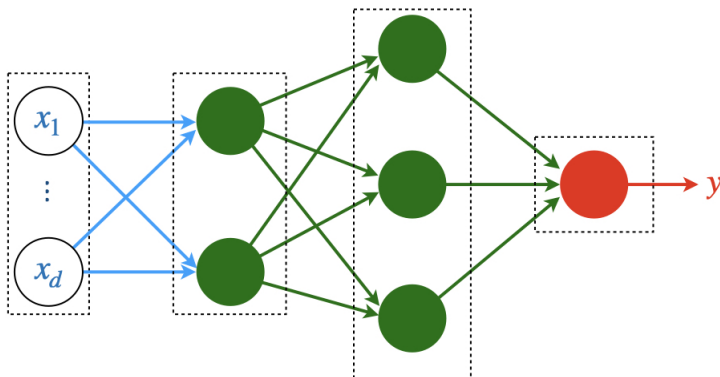
There is a rather rich literature on it

*This is why it has its own name: [Representation Learning](#)*

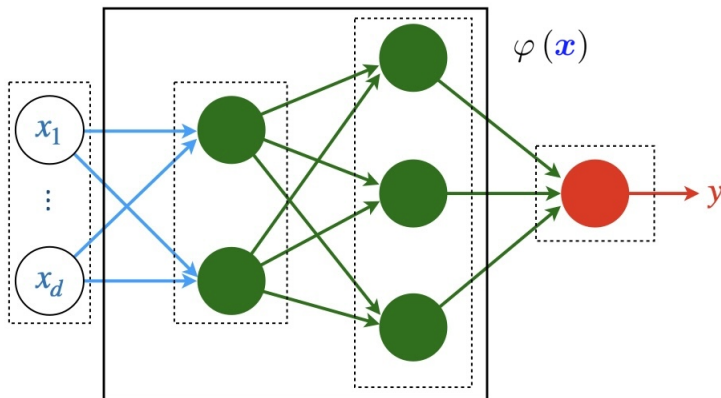
But it later turned out that

*By repeating the linear model over and over we can build excellent kernels*

# Deep Learning vs Representation Learning



# Deep Learning vs Representation Learning



## Observation: *Neural Networks Give Excellent Representation*

? *How can we find the right form for the kernel?*

This resembles what we know as *neural networks*:

*deep neural networks can make us great kernels!*

*NNs are hence what we are going to study next!*

## Further Read

- Bishop

- ↳ Chapter 6: *Sections 6.2 – 6.4*

**SVM**

- ESL

- ↳ Chapter 12: *Section 12.3 – 12.4*

**SVM**